Empowering Generations



Mariazeena Johnson, *42*
Chancellor, Sathyabama Institute of Science & Technology, Chennai

MESSAGE BOARD

"When a woman is empowered, a family is empowered. She not only influences a cohort, but a nation too"

↘ **BEST ADVICE SHE GOT** **'Be honest and courageous', from her *appa* (father)**

↘ **EXPLORER AT HEART** **Loves to travel, when time permits, and interact with people to learn about their cultures**

GROUNDED, WITH AN EASYGOING PERSONA, it's tough to imagine that behind the ever-smiling face of Mariazeena Johnson is a woman of steely determination who never shies away from taking challenges head-on.

As the chancellor of Sathyabama Institute of Science & Technology, a private deemed-to-be-university in Chennai, Mariazeena has been working tirelessly to make the 36-year-old institute a hub of academic excellence, research and innovation. So no surprises there that the institute—which started off as an engineering college in 1987 and received its university status in 2001—has been ranked 51st among all Indian universities in 2023 by the National Institutional Ranking Framework.

Daughter of the late Dr Jeppiaar, a politician and educationist who founded Sathyabama, Mariazeena has a doctorate in management studies from the University of Madras. She first joined Sathyabama as a director in 2001 and became its pro chancellor in 2016—the same year as her father died. She took over as chancellor two years later. Under her leadership, the institute has expanded further, and today offers 50 undergraduate and 25 postgraduate courses besides doctorates to over 15,000 students. During the institute's 32nd convocation in August, 3,504 UG, 551 PG and 104 Ph.D. students received their degrees.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has turned her institute into a hub of academic excellence with inclusivity at its core

A firm believer in the transformational power of education, Mariazeena says, "I always tell people around me: 'educate a person to empower a nation'." And it is for this very reason that inclusivity is at the core of her and her institute's ethos. The Anbu Foundation, which she co-founded with her husband Marie Johnson, offers full scholarship to meritorious students who lack the means to continue their education. Scores of physically challenged and underprivileged students have benefited from it. Mariazeena has also led a technology-driven upgrade of academics besides developing state-of-the-art infrastructure at the university. A Centre for Advanced Studies was set up last year.

"I'm fortunate to have grown up with a value system," says Mariazeena, "that instilled confidence in me to multi-task effortlessly." But when it gets too much to handle, her "support system"—Marie Johnson and their two daughters—"always rise to the occasion".

And what would she tell young women? "Go out and express yourself, and explore the possibilities," says Mariazeena. "Most importantly, finish your studies. Education brings a lot of respect and assists in every phase of life." Invaluable lesson that. ■

–Shelly Anand